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Here, then, we have another example of that difference of function which one and the same activity may perform in adult and juvenile society. The various devices that may have been used in the past for ordeals with results counted legally valid are employed by the children for breaking down the stratification of their group life, which is based on personal advantages of mind and body. It must, however, be admitted that occasionally the play-group uses an ordeal for determining whether one of its members is guilty. When children discover ants marching along, the nurses among them are ordered to put a finger into the column. The girl that wriggles about uneasily is bitten, while the experienced girl keeps still and is not attacked. The former is laughed at for having eaten the baby's food. Although it is said that on account of this ordeal many nurses resist the temptation to steal food, it resembles more a practical joke played on novices than a legal procedure.²

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The play-group knows, of course, a number of inducements and checks to behaviour which may assume a semi-legal aspect. Some of these have been described above. One more example will be given. There is a Solanum plant growing in waste places and bearing hard yellow fruits, the size of a large marble. Boys usually carry a few in the folds of their garments. They are sometimes thrown in fun at a child looking in another direction. Occasionally such an attack develops into a concerted action, punishing a boy for his unpopularity, his boasts, his unfair methods of play, and his betrayal of pasture secrets. From all sides the yellow missiles are hurled at him till he runs away in disgust or begins to weep.

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The configuration of the play-group has emerged from the foregoing discussion. It is a loose group of contemporaries of youthful age with a tendency to sexual exclusiveness. Leadership is determined by the vague criteria of physical and mental superiority tested in a multiplicity of competitive games, practical jokes, and contests; and it makes use of food control to maintain itself. Chance is appealed to to prevent rigidity of the system and magic is occasionally used to secure success. The leader, by whatever  280 method he obtained his position, retains it usually only for a short period. He chooses advisers and guardians to enforce his orders. This group of rulers determines the kind of game to be played, settles disputes, and imposes tasks on the average members. It also controls the working of the ideals of conduct emerging from the clash of individual interests within the group. The stability of the latter is greatly enhanced by the possibility of making its economic life independent. For, in addition to collecting and

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hunting smaller animals, as described above, boys are gradually advanced to independent positions at home. They are given plots and stock 'to make a start in life'. The partial cultural autonomy of the play-group is manifested in a variety of material objects unknown to adult society, which, although manufactured with crude tools and immature skill, yet suffice to keep alive the make-believe tendency of anticipatory play.¹

² Fortes, M., op. cit., p. 51, gives an example of a children's ordeal.

¹ Among some tribes, the community splits up into age-villages, 'each new generation of boys building together apart from their elders'. Cf. Stayt, H. A., op. cit., pp. 99–100, for an example of age-villages of a temporary nature; and Wilson, G., 'An Introduction to Nyakyusa Society', *Bantu Studies*, vol. x (1936), pp 253 *seq.*, and 'An African Morality', *Africa*, vol. ix (1936), p. 78, for permanent age-villages. Among the Bavenda, children move into their villages after the harvest, at the time of plenty; among the Nyakyusa, the boys continue to eat at their parents' home, though dwelling apart. Among the Chaga, where territorial segregation is impossible, on account of their method of dwelling, economic independence is more strongly marked. Cf. also Meyer, H., *Der Kilimandscharo*, p. 117. The explorer, at the end of last century, met some boys at Loitokitok, a Masai settlement at the foot of Mt. Kilimanjaro, who refused to sell their bows and arrows to him, because, as they said, they had no other means of livelihood.

Human Relations Area Files

755 Prospect Street

New Haven, CT 06511

General Inquiries: ✉ hraf@yale.edu

Issues and Bugs: ✉ hraf-support@yale.edu



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